the Afghan chiefs. Not only were the British starving, outmanoeuvred and cut off, they knew now that in addition they had lost any remaining moral high ground. Moreover the Afghans who had outsoldiered and outwitted them turned out not to be the crack troops from the mountains they had imagined them to be, but – in part at least – merely the 'tradesmen and artisans of Kabul, so that we had not even the melancholy satisfaction of knowing that we had been contending with the soldier tribes of the country'.[7]

After the death of Macnaghten, the badly wounded Eldred Pottinger was now the most senior British political officer left alive. Despite his telling Elphinstone and Shelton not to trust Akbar and urging that the only hope lay in heading for the Bala Hisar, Shelton continued to push hard for a withdrawal and Pottinger was put on a litter and sent out to negotiate the surrender and the terms of the retreat. 'I was hauled out of my sick room,' he wrote afterwards, 'and obliged to negotiate for the safety of a parcel of fools who were doing all they could to ensure their own destruction.'[8] In return for supplies and a safe passage, Akbar now demanded the surrender of all their remaining artillery as well as their treasure.

While waiting for food and baggage animals to be delivered, the British continued to be harassed. The worst offenders were the growing number of ghazis who increasingly clustered around the cantonment gates to bait, abuse and rob the now helpless invaders and those Afghans still friendly with them. 'Much annoyance was daily experienced from these people,' wrote Vincent Eyre.

> They were in the habit of plundering the peaceable dealers who flocked in from the city with grain and forage, the moment they issued from the cantonments. They even committed frequent assaults on our Sepoys, and orders to fire on them on such occasions were repeatedly solicited in vain, although it was well known that the chiefs themselves advised us to do so . . . The consequence was that our soldiers were daily constrained to endure the most insulting and contemptuous taunts and treatment from fellows whom a single charge of the bayonet would have scattered like chaff, but who were emboldened by the apparent tameness of our troops, which they doubtless attributed to the want of common pluck.[9]

Most harrowing of all was the knowledge that all the Afghans who still had any contact with the British were completely certain that the garrison were walking into a trap. On 29 December 1841, Hugh Johnson recorded in his diary: